

15. Orion, Cleitus, and Cephalus were also all beloved by Eos.
16. Perhaps an intentional play on the word *philommeides*, “laughter-loving,” a standard epithet of Aphrodite.
17. There is trouble in the text concerning Hesiod’s identification of the mountain as Dicte or Aegeum.
18. See William D. Furley and Jan Maarten Bremer, *Greek Hymns: Selected Cult Songs from the Archaic Period to the Hellenistic Period*. Vol. 1: *The Texts in Translation*, pp. 65–76. Vol. 2: *Greek Texts and Commentary*, pp. 1–20. *Studies and Texts in Classical Antiquity* 9 and 10 (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2001).
19. W. K. C. Guthrie, *The Greeks and Their Gods* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1955), p. 31.
20. The study of geometry is vital for Plato. In the *Republic* (7.527B), for example, he has Socrates say that geometry is the knowledge of what exists always, and Plutarch (*Quaestionum Convivialium* 8.1 [*Moralia* 718C; Loeb Vol. 9]) quotes Plato as saying that God is always doing geometry (or geometrizes continually, *aei geōmetrein*); that is, God is a geometer. Although Plutarch is not absolutely certain that these actual words are to be attributed to Plato, they accurately represent the essence of the Platonic and Socratic argument. Yet there is also abundant other evidence for the nonmathematical, the spiritual, and the mystical aspects of Plato’s philosophy, epitomized in his visionary Myth of Er, narrated by Socrates, which is translated on pages 362–367.

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Zeus' Rise to Power: The Creation of Mortals

My mother Themis or Earth (Ge), if you like, for she has one form but many names, would often foretell the future that would be accomplished saying, "not through strength nor by force, but by guile inevitably will those who are more powerful gain mastery."

—AESCHYLUS, *Prometheus Bound* 211–215

The Titanomachy: Zeus Defeats His Father, Cronus

When Zeus had grown to maturity, Cronus was beguiled into bringing up all that he had swallowed, first the stone and then the children.¹ Zeus then waged war against his father with his disgorged brothers and sisters as allies: Hestia, Demeter, Hera, Hades, and Poseidon. Allied with him as well were the **Hecatonchires** and the **Cyclopes**, for he had released them from the depths of the earth, where their father, Uranus, had imprisoned them. The Hecatonchires were invaluable in hurling stones with their hundred-handed dexterity, and the Cyclopes forged for him his mighty thunder and lightning. On the other side, allied with Cronus, were the Titans—with the important exception of Themis and her son Prometheus, both of whom allied with Zeus. (Note that for Hesiod, Clymene is the mother of Prometheus.) Atlas, the brother of Prometheus, was an important leader on the side of Cronus.

This battle, known as the Titanomachy, was of epic proportions, Zeus fighting from Mt. Olympus, Cronus from Mt. Othrys. The struggle is said to have lasted ten years.² An excerpt from Hesiod conveys the magnitude and ferocity of the conflict (*Theogony* 678–721):

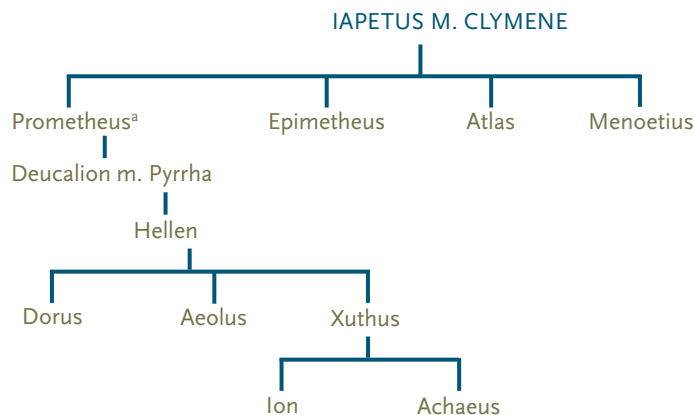


The boundless sea echoed terribly, earth resounded with the great roar, wide heaven trembled and groaned, and high Olympus was shaken from its base by the onslaught of the immortals; the quakes came thick and fast and, with the dread din of the endless chase and mighty weapons, reached down to gloomy Tartarus. (678–683)

Thus they hurled their deadly weapons against one another. The cries of both sides as they shouted reached up to starry heaven, for they came together with a great clamor. Then Zeus did not hold back his might any longer, but now immediately his heart was filled with strength and he showed clearly all his force. He came direct from heaven and Olympus hurling perpetual lightning, and the bolts with flashes and thunder flew in succession from his stout hand with a dense whirling of holy flame. Earth, the giver of life, roared, everywhere aflame, and on all sides the vast woods crackled loudly with the fire. The whole of the land boiled, and as well the streams of Ocean, and the barren sea. The hot blast engulfed the earth-born Titans and the endless blaze reached the divine aether; the flashing gleam of the thunder and lightning blinded the eyes even of the mighty. Unspeakable heat possessed Chaos. (684–700)

The sight seen by the eyes and the sound heard by the ears were as if earth and wide heaven above collided; for the din as the gods met one another in strife was as great as the crash that would have arisen if earth were dashed down by heaven falling on her from above. The winds mingled the confusion of tremor, dust, thunder, and the flashing bolts of lightning (the shafts of great Zeus), and carried the noise and the shouts into the midst of both sides. The terrifying clamor of fearful strife arose, and the might of their deeds was shown forth. They attacked one another and fought relentlessly in mighty encounters until the battle was decided. (700–712)

The Hecatonchires (Cottus, Briareus, and Gyes), insatiate of battle, were among the foremost to rouse the bitter strife; they hurled three hundred rocks, one right after another, from their staunch hands and covered the Titans with a cloud of missiles and sent them down far beneath the broad ways of the earth



^aThemis is the mother of Prometheus, according to Aeschylus

Figure 4.1. The Family of Prometheus

to Tartarus and bound them in harsh bonds, having conquered them with their hands even though they were great of spirit. The distance from earth to gloomy Tartarus is as great as that of heaven from earth. (713–721)

The Hecatonchires guarded the Titans imprisoned in Tartarus. Atlas was punished with the task of holding up the sky. In some accounts, when Zeus became secure in power he eventually relented and gave the Titans their freedom.

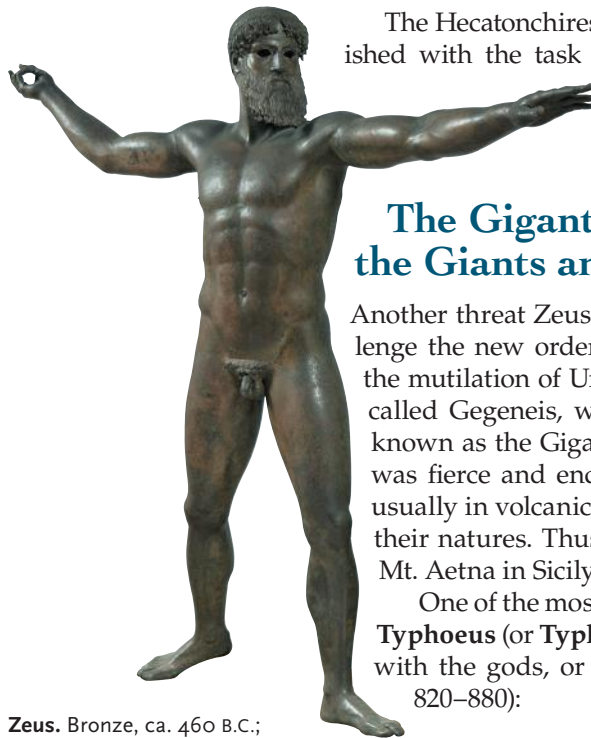
The Gigantomachy: Zeus Defeats the Giants and Typhoeus

Another threat Zeus had to face came from giants that Earth produced to challenge the new order of the gods or that had been born when the blood from the mutilation of Uranus fell upon the ground. These monstrous creatures are called Gegeneis, which means “earthborn.” The many details of this battle, known as the Gigantomachy, vary, but it is generally agreed that the struggle was fierce and ended with the imprisonment of the giants under the earth, usually in volcanic regions where they betray their presence by the violence of their natures. Thus, for example, the giant Enceladus writhes under volcanic Mt. Aetna in Sicily.

One of the most vicious of the monsters who opposed Zeus was the dragon **Typhoeus** (or **Typhaon** or **Typhon**). He sometimes joins others in their conflict with the gods, or he may do battle alone, as in Hesiod’s account (*Theogony* 820–880):

When Zeus had driven the Titans from heaven, vast Gaea brought forth the youngest of her children through the love of Tartarus and the agency of golden Aphrodite. The hands of the mighty god were strong in any undertaking and his feet were weariless. From the shoulders of this frightening dragon a hundred snake heads grew, flickering their dark tongues; fire blazed from the eyes under the brows of all the dreadful heads, and the flames burned as he glared. In all the terrible heads voices emitted all kinds of amazing sounds; for at one time he spoke so that the gods understood, at another his cries were those of a proud bull bellowing in his invincible might; sometimes he produced the pitiless roars of a courageous lion, or again his yelps were like those of puppies, wondrous to hear, or at another time he would hiss; and the great mountains resounded in echo. (820–835)

Now on that day of his birth an irremediable deed would have been accomplished and he would have become the ruler of mortals and immortals, if the father of gods and men had not taken swift notice and thundered loudly and fiercely; the earth resounded terribly on all sides and as well the wide heaven above, the sea, the streams of Ocean, and the depths of Tartarus. Great Olympus shook under the immortal feet of the lord as he rose up and earth gave a groan. The burning heat from them both, with the thunder and lightning, scorching winds, and flaming bolts reached down to seize the dark-colored sea. The whole land was aboil and heaven and the deep; and the huge waves surged around and about the shores at the onslaught of the immortals, and a quake began its tremors without ceasing. Hades who rules over the dead below shook,



Zeus. Bronze, ca. 460 B.C.; height 82 in. The viewer feels awe at the superhuman size, divine nudity, and commanding mien of the god as he hurls his thunderbolt. This statue was found in the sea off Cape Artemisium (at the northern end of Euboea). The identification with Zeus is more likely than with Poseidon hurling his trident. (*National Archaeological Museum, Athens*)

Gigantomachies and Civic Pride

The battle between the Olympian gods and the giants was often used to represent the triumph of Greek civilization, or of a particular Greek city, over barbarian disorder. In the sculptural program of the Parthenon at Athens (see pp. 177–180), for example, the Gigantomachy was portrayed on the east side of the outer frieze. The most splendid example of this artistic and civic symbolism was the Great Altar of Pergamum (see pp. 88–89), erected during the reign of Eumenes II (181–158 B.C.) to glorify victory over an unknown enemy, probably Gallic invaders. Greek altars were usually erected in the open air in front of the god's temple. Here the altar was independent of the temple, while the chief gods of Pergamum, Zeus and Athena, had their own separate sanctuaries. It was built on a ledge high up on the acropolis of Pergamum: the altar itself stood in an unroofed inner court, surrounded by an Ionic portico and approached by wide steps, on either side of which the north and south wings of the portico were extended. On the outside of the portico was a colossal marble frieze of the Gigantomachy, 100 meters long and 2.5 meters high. The Olympian gods were shown, each vanquishing a giant: the gods' names were painted on the cornice above the frieze and the giants' names were inscribed on the stone course below. The frieze was painted in bright colors, and (unlike pedimental sculptures) was designed to be seen by the viewer at close quarters. A second, smaller frieze (58 meters long) of the myth of Telephus (see pp. 485–486) was carved on the inner back wall of the portico. It honored his father, Heracles, whose help was crucial in the victory of the gods over the giants. The altar and its sculptures were excavated by German archaeologists between 1878 and 1886, who were allowed to take their finds to Berlin and restore them. The subsequent history of the altar in two world wars, including transportation to and from Russia after World War II, is an ironic commentary on the symbolic themes of the friezes. See John Boardman (ed.), *The Oxford History of Classical Art* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993), pp. 164–166.

as did the Titans, the allies of Cronus, in the bottom of Tartarus, from the endless din and terrifying struggle. (836–852)

When Zeus had lifted up the weapons of his might, thunder and lightning and the blazing bolts, he leaped down from Olympus and struck, and blasted on all sides the marvelous heads of the terrible monster. When he had flogged him with blows, he hurled him down, maimed, and vast earth gave a groan. A flame flared up from the god as he was hit by the bolts in the glens of the dark craggy mountain where he was struck down. A great part of vast earth was burned by the immense conflagration and melted like tin heated by the craft of artisans in open crucibles, or like iron which although the hardest of all is softened by blazing fire and melts in the divine earth through the craft of Hephaestus. Thus the earth melted in the flame of the blazing fire. And Zeus in the rage of his anger hurled him into broad Tartarus. (853–868)

From Typhoeus arise the winds that blow the mighty rains; but not Notus, Boreas, and Zephyr³ who brings good weather, for they are sprung from the gods and a great benefit for mortals. But the others from Typhoeus blow over the sea at random; some fall upon the shadowy deep and do great harm to mortals, raging with their evil blasts. They blow this way and that and scatter ships

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and destroy sailors. Those who encounter them on the sea have no defense against their evil. Others blowing over the vast blossoming land destroy the lovely works of mortals born on earth, filling them with dust and harsh confusion. (869–880)

Later versions have it that Heracles was an ally of Zeus in the battle; the giants could be defeated only if the gods had a mortal as their ally. In addition, Earth produced a magic plant that would make the giants invincible; Zeus by a clever stratagem plucked it for himself.

The attempt of the giants Otus and Ephialtes to storm heaven by piling the mountains Olympus, Ossa, and Pelion upon one another is sometimes linked to the battle of the giants or treated as a separate attack on the power of Zeus. In fact, there is considerable confusion in the tradition concerning details and characters in the battle of the giants (Gigantomachy) and the battle of the Titans (Titanomachy). Both conflicts may be interpreted as reflecting the triumph of the more benign powers of nature over the wilder powers or of civilization over savagery. Historically, it is likely that they represent the fact of conquest and amalgamation when, in about 2000 B.C., the Greek-speaking invaders brought with them their own gods, with Zeus as their chief, and triumphed over the deities of the existing peoples in the peninsula of Greece.

The Creation of Mortals

Various versions of the birth of mortals existed side by side in the ancient world. Very often they are the creation of Zeus alone, or of Zeus and the other gods. Sometimes immortals and mortals spring from the same source. A dominant tradition depicts Prometheus as the creator of man; and sometimes woman is created later and separately through the designs of Zeus.

After describing the creation of the universe and animal life out of the elements of Chaos, Ovid tells about the birth of mortals, depicting the superiority and lofty ambition of this highest creature in the order of things (*Metamorphoses* 1. 76–88); Ovid's "man" (*homo*) epitomizes the human race.

Until now there was no animal more godlike than these and more capable of high intelligence and able to dominate all the rest. Then man was born; either the creator of the universe, originator of a better world, fashioned him from divine seed, or earth, recently formed and separated from the lofty aether, retained seeds from its kindred sky and was mixed with rain water by Prometheus, the son of Iapetus, and fashioned by him into the likeness of the gods who control all. While other animals look down to the ground, man was given a lofty visage and ordered to look up to the sky and fully erect lift his face to the stars. Thus earth that had been crude and without shape was transformed and took on the figure of man unknown before.

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A fragment attributed to Hesiod (no. 268 Rzach; no. 382 Merkelbach and West) adds that Athena breathed life into the clay. At Panopea in Boeotia, stones were identified in historical times as solidified remains of the clay used by Prometheus.

The Four or Five Ages

Ovid goes on to describe the four ages: gold, silver, bronze, and iron. We prefer, however, to excerpt Hesiod's earlier account of **The Five Ages of Man**, since he feels compelled to include the historical age of heroes. After he has recounted the story of Pandora and her jar, his introduction to the description of the five ages suggests both the multiplicity of versions of the creation of mortals and the futility of even attempting to reconcile the diverse accounts (*Works and Days* 106–201).

If you like, I shall offer a fine and skillful summary of another tale and you ponder it in your heart: how gods and mortal humans came into being from the same origin. (106–108)



Audio

THE AGE OF GOLD

At the very first, the immortals who have their homes on Olympus made a golden race of mortal humans. They existed at the time when Cronus was king in heaven, and they lived as gods with carefree hearts completely without toil or trouble. Terrible old age did not come upon them at all, but always with vigor in their hands and their feet they took joy in their banquets removed from all evils. They died as though overcome by sleep. And all good things were theirs; the fertile land of its own accord bore fruit ungrudgingly in abundance. They in harmony and in peace managed their affairs with many good things, rich in flocks and beloved of the blessed gods. But then the earth covered over this race. Yet they inhabit the earth and are called holy spirits, who are good and ward off evils, as the protectors of mortal beings, and are providers of wealth, since they keep watch over judgments and cruel deeds, wandering over the whole earth wrapped in air. For they have these royal prerogatives. (109–126)

THE AGE OF SILVER

Then those who have their home on Olympus next made a second race of silver, far worse than the one of gold and unlike it both physically and mentally. A child was brought up by the side of his dear mother for a hundred years, playing in his house as a mere baby. But when they grew up and reached the measure of their prime they lived for only a short time and in distress because of their senselessness. For they could not restrain their wanton arrogance against one another and they did not wish to worship the blessed immortals or sacrifice at their holy altars, as is customary and right for human beings. Then in his anger, Zeus, the son of Cronus, hid them away because they did not give the blessed gods who inhabit Olympus their due. Then the earth covered over this race too. And they dwell under the earth and are called blessed by mortals, and although second, nevertheless honor attends them also. (127–142)

THE AGE OF BRONZE

Father Zeus made another race of mortal humans, the third, of bronze and not at all like the one of silver; terrible and mighty because of their spears of ash, they pursued the painful and violent deeds of Ares. They did not eat bread at all but were terrifying and had dauntless hearts of adamant. Great was their might,

The Altar of Zeus at Pergamon

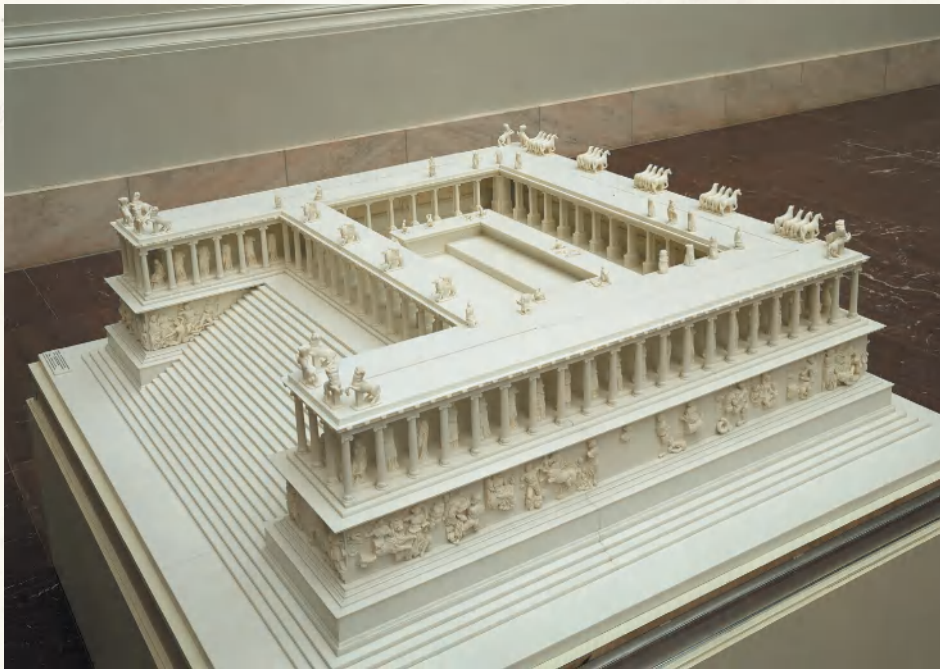
The kingdom of Pergamon rose to world prominence in the years following Alexander's conquests. After the death of Alexander the Great in 323 B.C., and the subsequent fragmentation of his empire among his successors, Pergamon became an independent kingdom ruled by one family, the Attalids, who would remain in power until the last member of the dynasty, Attalus III, bequeathed the kingdom to Rome in 133 B.C. The kingdom of Pergamon reached the height of its prestige and power under Eumenes II (197–159 B.C.). During this period, the city attained a level of culture and sophistication on a par with Athens and Alexandria. It housed one of the greatest libraries in the ancient world; only the Great Library of Alexandria surpassed its resources. Of the many industries that Pergamon would exploit, the export of parchment became the most lucrative and even came to threaten Egypt's monopoly of the papyrus trade. The word *parchment*, which refers to animal skins treated to be used as a viable alternative to papyrus, is a corruption of the name Pergamon itself.

Athena Defeats Alcyoneus.

Detail from the east frieze of the Great Altar of Pergamum, between 180 and 159 B.C.; height of panel 8 ft. 2 in. Athena, shield on her left arm and aegis (with the Gorgon's head) on her breast, strides energetically in the center, as a winged Nike (figure of Victory) flies from the right to place a garland on her head. With her right hand Athena seizes the hair of the giant Alcyoneus, who is helpless to resist despite his massive wings and serpentine legs. To the right Gaia, mother of Alcyoneus, rises from below, separated by Athena's left leg from her son and so prevented from transferring to him by her touch renewed strength and immortality. (Erich Lessing/*Art Resource*, NY)



Under Eumenes, the city of Pergamon underwent remarkable development and became a center of art and culture. In particular, it came to be in the vanguard of some of the most important developments in Hellenistic sculpture, which can best be appreciated in the remains of the Altar of Zeus, which Eumenes also had constructed. The podium was decorated with relief sculptures depicting the Gigantomachy, the mythic battle between the Olympians and the Gegeneis (Earth-born). The relief is cut very deeply. It is a maelstrom of activity with a profusion of forms and decorative motifs. The melodramatic, emotional intensity of the figures is one of the hallmarks of Hellenistic sculpture, a direct contrast with the classical restraint so evident in earlier works, such as the sculptural decoration on the Parthenon (see pp. 177–180), though there are allusions to the earlier sculptural legacy. For example, the image of Athena victorious in battle (reproduced here), striding to the right, is mirrored by the image of Zeus striding to the left (not shown). The positioning of both Zeus and Athena is meant to recall the positioning of the figures of Athena and Hephaestus on the west pediment of the Parthenon.



The Pergamene Altar. The Great Altar of Zeus, commissioned by Eumenes II, originally stood on the imposing acropolis of Pergamon. Constructed ca. 175 B.C., the structure was composed of an Ionic colonnade with two projecting wings, atop a massive podium. The broad stairway led through the colonnade to the altar. The frieze along the base depicting the Gigantomachy is about 400 feet long and 7 feet in height. For Eumenes, this mythic paradigm memorialized his victories over the invading Gauls, and so, like the sculptural program of the Parthenon (see p. 177), myth is used to prefigure a contemporary reality. (*bpk/Antikensammlung, SMB/Johannes Laurentius*)

and unconquerable hands grew upon their strong limbs out of their shoulders. Of bronze were their arms, of bronze were their homes, and they worked with bronze implements. Black iron there was not. When they had been destroyed by their own hands, they went down into the dark house of chill Hades without leaving a name. Black death seized them, although they were terrifying, and they left the bright light of the sun. (143–155)

THE AGE OF HEROES

But when the earth covered over this race too, again Zeus, the son of Cronus, made still another, the fourth on the nourishing earth, valiant in war and more 40 just, a godlike race of heroic men, who are called demigods, and who preceded our own race on the vast earth. Evil war and dread battle destroyed some of them under seven-gated Thebes in the land of Cadmus as they battled for the flocks of Oedipus; the end of death closed about others after they had been led in ships over the great depths of the sea to Troy for the sake of Helen of the beautiful hair. Some, father Zeus, the son of Cronus, sent to dwell at the ends of the earth where he has them live their lives; these happy heroes inhabit the Islands of the Blessed with carefree hearts by the deep swirling stream of Ocean. For them the fruitful earth bears honey-sweet fruit that ripens three times a 50 year. Far from the immortals, Cronus rules as king over them; for the father of gods and men released him from his bonds. Honor and glory attend these last in equal measure. (156–173c)

THE AGE OF IRON

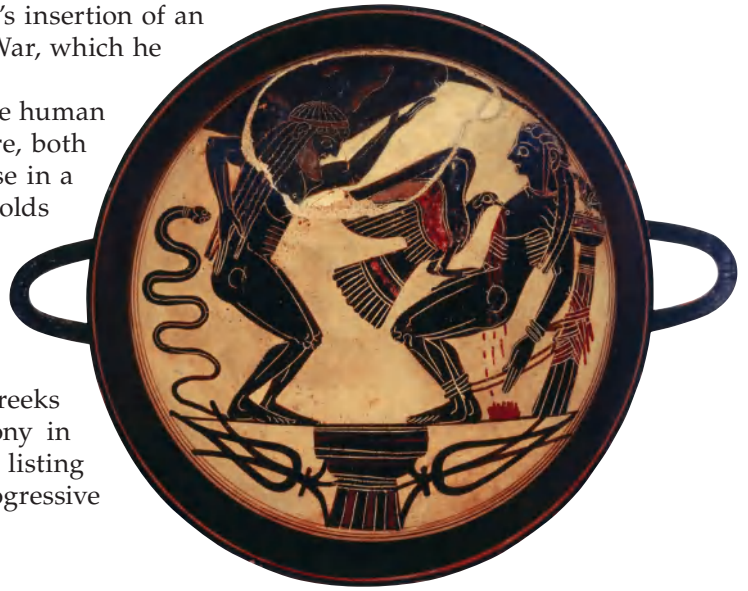
Far-seeing Zeus again made still another race who live on the nourishing earth. Oh, would that I were not a man of the fifth generation but either had died before or had been born later. Now indeed the race is of iron. For they never cease from toil and woe by day, nor from being destroyed in the night. The gods will give them difficult troubles, but good will be mingled with their evils. Zeus will destroy this race of mortals too, whenever it comes to pass that they are born with gray hair on their temples. And a father will not be in harmony with his children nor his children with him, nor guest with host, nor friend with friend, and a 60 brother will not be loved as formerly. As they grow old quickly they will dishonor their parents, and they will find fault, blaming them with harsh words and not knowing respect for the gods, since their right is might. They will not sustain their aged parents in repayment for their upbringing. One will destroy the city of another. No esteem will exist for the one who is true to an oath or just or good; rather mortals will praise the arrogance and evil of the wicked. Justice will be might and shame will not exist. The evil person will harm the better, speaking against him unjustly and he will swear an oath besides. Envy, shrill and ugly and with evil delight, will attend all human beings in their woe. Then Aidos and Nemesis both⁴ will forsake them and go, their beautiful forms shrouded in white, 70 from the wide earth to Olympus among the company of the gods. For mortals sorry griefs will be left and there will be no defense against evil. (173d–201)

The bitterness and pessimism of this picture of his own age of iron are typical of Hesiod's generally crabbed, severe, and moral outlook. But his designation of the five ages reflects a curious blend of fact and fiction. Historically his *was* the age of iron, introduced into Greece at the time of the invasions that

brought the age of bronze to a close. Hesiod's insertion of an age of heroes reflects the fact of the Trojan War, which he cannot ignore.

This conception of the deterioration of the human race has been potent in subsequent literature, both ancient and modern. The vision of a paradise in a golden age when all was well inevitably holds fascination for some, whether imagined as long ago or merely in the good old days of their youth.⁵

It would be wrong to imply that this theory of the degeneration of the human race was the only one current among the Greeks and Romans. Prometheus' eloquent testimony in Aeschylus' play, translated on pages 96–97, listing his gifts to humans, rests on the belief in progressive stages from savagery to civilization.⁶



Prometheus against Zeus

In the *Theogony* (507–616), Hesiod tells the stories of Prometheus and his conflict with Zeus, with the human race as the pawn in this gigantic clash of divine wills. He begins with the birth of Prometheus and explains how Prometheus tricked Zeus (507–569):

Iapetus led away the girl Clymene, an Oceanid, and they went together in the same bed; and she bore to him a child, stout-hearted Atlas; she also brought forth Menoetius, of very great renown, and devious and clever Prometheus, and **Epimetheus**,⁷ who was faulty in judgment and from the beginning was an evil for mortals who work for their bread. For he was the first to accept from Zeus the virgin woman he had formed. Far-seeing Zeus struck arrogant Menoetius with his smoldering bolts and hurled him down into Erebus because of his presumption and excessive pride. Atlas stands and holds the wide heaven with his head and tireless hands through the force of necessity at the edge of the earth, and in the sight of the clear-voiced Hesperides; this fate Zeus in his wisdom allotted him. (507–520)

And Zeus bound devious and wily Prometheus with hard and inescapable bonds, after driving a shaft through his middle; and roused up a long-winged eagle against him that used to eat his immortal liver. But all that the long-winged bird would eat during the whole day would be completely restored in equal measure during the night. Heracles, the mighty son of Alcmena of the lovely ankles, killed it and rid the son of Iapetus from this evil plague and released him from his suffering, not against the will of Olympian Zeus who rules from on high, so that the renown of Theban-born Heracles might be still greater than before on the bountiful earth. Thus he respected his famous son with this token of honor. Although he had been enraged, the mighty son of Cronus gave up the anger that he had held previously because Prometheus had matched his wits against him. (521–534)

For when the gods and mortals quarreled at Mecone,⁸ then Prometheus with quick intelligence divided up a great ox and set the pieces out in an attempt

Atlas and Prometheus. Laconian black-figure cup, ca. 560 B.C. The two Titans endure the punishments of Zeus: Atlas holds up the star-studded heavens and helplessly watches the vulture (or eagle) attack his brother, Prometheus, who is bound to a column. The motif of the column is repeated in the lower register, with lotus-leaf decoration, while the snake on the left seems not to be part of the narrative. (Vatican Museums)

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to deceive the mind of Zeus. For the one group in the dispute he placed flesh and the rich and fatty innards on the hide and wrapped them all up in the ox's paunch; for the other group he arranged and set forth with devious art the white bones of the ox, wrapping them up in white fat. (535–541)

Then the father of gods and men spoke to him: "Son of Iapetus, most renowned of all lords, my fine friend, how partisan has been your division of the portions!" Thus Zeus whose wisdom is immortal spoke in derision. Wily Prometheus answered with a gentle smile, as he did not forget his crafty trick. "Most glorious Zeus, greatest of the gods who exist forever, choose whichever of the two the heart in your breast urges." He spoke with crafty intent. (542–549)

But Zeus whose wisdom is immortal knew and was not unaware of the trick. And he foresaw in his heart evils for mortals, which would be accomplished. He took up in both his hands the white fat, and his mind was enraged, and anger took hold of his heart as he saw the white bones of the ox arranged with crafty art. For this reason the races of human beings on earth burn the white bones for the immortals on the sacrificial altars. (550–557)

Zeus the cloud-gatherer was greatly angered and spoke to him: "Son of Iapetus, my fine friend, who know thoughts that surpass those of everyone, so you have then not yet forgotten your crafty arts." Thus Zeus whose wisdom is immortal spoke in anger. From this time on he always remembered the deceit and did not give the power of weariless fire out of ash trees to mortals who dwell on the earth. (558–564)

But the noble son of Iapetus tricked him by stealing in a hollow fennel stalk the gleam of weariless fire that is seen from afar. High-thundering Zeus was stung to the depths of his being and angered in his heart as he saw among mortals the gleam of fire seen from afar. (565–569)

The Creation of Pandora

Hesiod goes on to describe the dread consequence of Zeus' anger at Prometheus for his theft of fire (*Theogony* 570–616):

Immediately he contrived an evil thing for mortals in recompense for the fire. The renowned lame god, Hephaestus, fashioned out of earth the likeness of a modest maiden according to the will of the son of Cronus. Bright-eyed Athena clothed and arrayed her in silvery garments and with her hands arranged on her head an embroidered veil, wondrous to behold. And Pallas Athena put around her head lovely garlands of budding flowers and greenery. And she placed on her head a golden crown that the renowned lame god himself made, fashioning it with his hands as a favor to his father, Zeus. On it he wrought much intricate detail, wondrous to behold, of the countless animals which the land and the sea nourish; many he fixed on it, amazing creations, like living creatures with voices; and its radiant loveliness shone forth in profusion. (570–584)

When he had fashioned the beautiful evil in recompense for the blessing of fire, he led her out where the other gods and mortals were, exulting in the raiment provided by the gleaming-eyed daughter of a mighty father. Amazement took hold of the immortal gods and mortals as they saw the sheer trick, from which human beings could not escape. For from her is the race of the female sex, the ruinous tribes of women, a great affliction, who live with mortal men, helpmates not in ruinous poverty but in excessive wealth, just as when in overhanging hives bees feed the drones, conspirators in evil works; the bees each

day, the whole time to the setting of the sun, are busy and deposit the white 20
honeycombs, but the drones remain within the covered hives and scrape
together the toil of others into their own belly. Thus in the same way high-
thundering Zeus made women, conspirators in painful works, for mortal
men. (585–602)

He also contrived a second evil as recompense for the blessing of fire;
whoever flees marriage and the troublesome deeds of women and does
not wish to marry comes to ruinous old age destitute of anyone to care for
him. He does not lack a livelihood while he is living but, when he has died,
distant relatives divide up the inheritance. And again even for the one to
whom the fate of acquiring a good and compatible wife in marriage falls 30
as his lot, evil continually contends with good throughout his life. Whoever
begets mischievous children lives with a continuous sorrow in his breast; in
heart and soul the evil is incurable. Thus it is not possible to go beyond the
will of Zeus nor to deceive him. For not even the goodly Prometheus, son of
Iapetus, got out from under his heavy wrath and a great bondage held him
fast, even though he was very clever. (602–616)

Once again Hesiod's dominant note is despair. He provides another
dismal account of Prometheus in the *Works and Days* (47–105); despite some
minor repetitions, it is worth quoting for its elaboration of the theft of fire
and its variations on the creation of woman. The evil is now specifically
named; she is Pandora, which means “all gifts,” and she has a jar (see
figure, p. 94, where she holds a box).⁹

Zeus, angered in his heart, hid the means of human livelihood because Wily
Prometheus deceived him. And so he devised for human beings sorrowful
troubles. He hid fire. Then the good son of Iapetus, Prometheus, stole it for
human beings from wise Zeus in a hollow reed, without Zeus who delights
in thunder seeing it. (47–53)

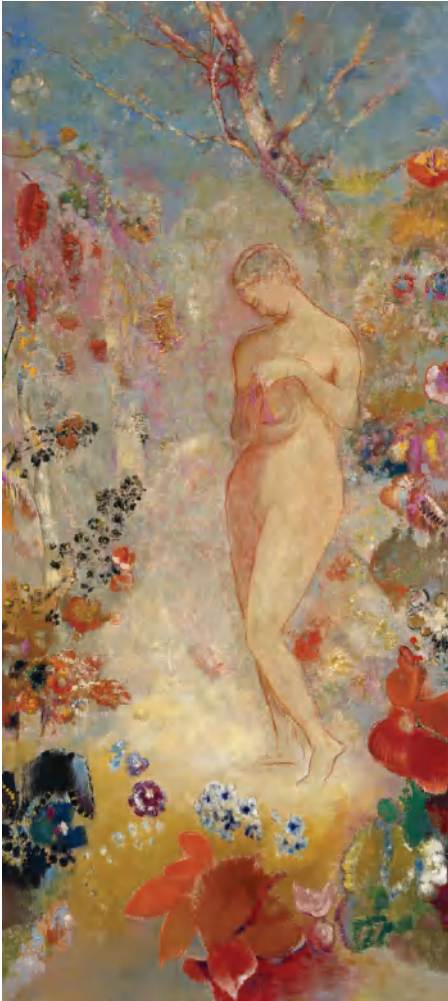
But then Zeus the cloud-gatherer was roused to anger and spoke to him:
“Son of Iapetus, who know how to scheme better than all others, you are
pleased that you stole fire and outwitted me—a great misery for you and
men who are about to be. As recompense for the fire I shall give them an
evil in which all may take delight in their hearts as they embrace it.” (54–58) 10

Thus he spoke and the father of gods and men burst out laughing. He
ordered renowned Hephaestus as quickly as possible to mix earth with
water and to implant in it a human voice and strength and to fashion the
beautiful and desirable form of a maiden, with a face like that of an im-
mortal goddess. But he ordered Athena to teach her the skills of weaving
at the artful loom, and golden Aphrodite to shed grace about her head and
painful longing and sorrows that permeate the body. And he commanded
the guide Hermes, slayer of Argus, to put in her the mind of a bitch and the
character of a thief. (59–68)

Thus he spoke and they obeyed their lord Zeus, son of Cronus. At once 20
the famous lame god molded out of earth the likeness of a modest maiden
according to the will of Zeus. Bright-eyed Athena clothed and arrayed her,
and the Graces and mistress Persuasion adorned her with golden necklaces.
The beautiful-haired Seasons crowned her with spring flowers, and Pallas
Athena fitted out her body with every adornment. Then the guide and slayer
of Argus contrived in her breast lies and wheedling words and a thievish



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Pandora, by Odilon Redon (1840–1916); oil on canvas, ca. 1910; 56 ½ × 24 ½ in. Pandora, holding her box, is framed by jewellike flowers, but above her is a leafless tree. Redon used symbols “to clothe ideas in a sensuous form” (in the words of the *Symbolist Manifesto* of 1886). This painting is nearly contemporary with Freud’s *Interpretation of Dreams* (1900). Like Freud, Redon used the symbols of mythology to express his innermost ideas and emotions. (Image copyright © The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look

nature, as loud-thundering Zeus directed. And the herald of the gods put in her a voice, and named this woman Pandora, because all who have their homes on Olympus gave her a gift, a bane to men who work for their bread. (69–82)

But when the Father had completed this sheer impossible trick he sent the swift messenger of the gods, the renowned slayer of Argus, to bring it as a gift for Epimetheus. And Epimetheus did not think about how Prometheus had told him never to accept a gift from Olympian Zeus but to send it back in case that in some way it turned out to be evil for mortals. But he received the gift and when indeed he had the evil he realized. (83–89) 30

Previously the races of human beings used to live completely free from evils and hard work and painful diseases, which hand over mortals to the Fates. For mortals soon grow old amidst evil. But the woman removed the great cover of the jar with her hands and scattered the evils within and for mortals devised sorrowful troubles. (90–95) 40

Hope alone remained within there in the unbreakable home under the edge of the jar and did not fly out of doors. For the lid of the jar stopped her before she could, through the will of the cloud-gatherer Zeus who bears the aegis. But the other thousands of sorrows wander among human beings, for the earth and the sea are full of evils. Of their own accord diseases roam among human beings some by day, others by night bringing evils to mortals in silence, since Zeus in his wisdom took away their voice. Thus it is not at all possible to escape the will of Zeus. (96–105)

Interpretations of the Myths of Prometheus and Pandora

The etiology of the myth of Prometheus is perhaps the most obvious of its many fascinating elements. It explains procedure in the ritual of sacrifice and the origin of fire—Promethean fire, the symbol of defiant progress. Prometheus himself is the archetype of the culture god or hero ultimately responsible for all the arts and sciences.¹⁰ Prometheus is also the archetype of the divine or heroic trickster (cf. Hermes and Odysseus).

Other archetypal themes once again abound, and embedded in them is a mythological etiology that provides causes and explanations for various eternal mysteries: What is the nature of god or the gods? Where did we come from? Do we have a dual nature, an earthly, mortal body and a divine, immortal soul? Are human beings the pawns in a war of rivalry between supernatural powers? Did they lose a paradise or evolve from savagery to civilization? What is the source of and reason for evil? In the person of Pandora, the existence of evil and pain in the world is accounted for.

The elements in the myth of the creation of woman reveal attitudes common among early societies. Like Eve, for example, Pandora is created after man and she is responsible for his troubles. Why should this be so? The answer is complex, but inevitably it must lay bare the prejudices and mores inherent in the social structure. But some detect as well the fundamental truths of allegory and see the woman and her jar as symbols of the drive and lure of procreation, the womb and birth and life, the source of all our woes.¹¹

Pandora's Box

Hesiod identifies the jar that Pandora presents to Epimetheus as a *pithos*, which usually means a large earthenware container for storing provisions such as wine or oil. It was not until medieval times, it seems, that a *pithos* became a *pyxis*, that is, a small portable vessel. Erasmus of Rotterdam has been identified as the one who first translated *pithos* as *pyxis* (in 1508). Ever since, if not before, Pandora's jar has become in art and literature a container of various easily carried shapes, including often that of a box.¹²

The theme of the first woman as the bringer of evil is particularly fraught with social, political, and moral implications. The most obvious interpretation of Hesiod is that Pandora was the first woman (like Eve in the Bible) and responsible for evil. Thus, for the Greeks the world, before Pandora, was populated only by men—an extremely difficult concept. Did Prometheus create only men out of clay? Hesiod's account is riddled with irreconcilable contradictions because various stories have been awkwardly but poetically conflated. In the myth of the Ages of Mankind both men and women are created by Zeus or the gods, and both men and women are held responsible for evil, for which they are punished by the gods. Should we assume that Pandora was sent with her jar of evils (and Hope) to a happy humankind? At any rate, amidst all this confusion, Hesiod is more accurately condemned as a misanthropist, rather than only as a misogynist.

Details in the story of Pandora are disturbing in their tantalizing ambiguity. What is Hope doing in the jar along with countless evils? If it is a good, it is a curious inclusion. If it too is an evil, why is it stopped at the rim? What then is its precise nature, whether a blessing or a curse? Is Hope the one thing that enables human beings to survive the terrors of this life and inspires them with lofty ambition? Yet is it also by its very character delusive and blind, luring them on to prolong their misery? It is tempting to see in Aeschylus' play *Prometheus Bound* an interpretation and elaboration: human beings were without hope until Prometheus gave it to them along with the benefit of fire. The hope Prometheus bestows on mortals is both blind and a blessing. The pertinent dialogue between Prometheus and the chorus of Oceanids runs as follows (248–252):

PROMETHEUS: I stopped mortals from foreseeing their fate.
 CHORUS: What sort of remedy did you find for this plague?
 PROMETHEUS: I planted in them blind hopes.
 CHORUS: This was a great advantage that you gave mortals.
 PROMETHEUS: And besides I gave them fire.

Fundamental to both Hesiod and Aeschylus is the conception of Zeus as the oppressor of humankind and Prometheus as its benefactor. In Aeschylus the clash of divine wills echoes triumphantly through the ages. His portrait, more than any other, offers the towering image of Prometheus as the Titan, the bringer of fire, the vehement and weariless champion against oppression, the mighty symbol for art, literature, and music of all time.

Aeschylus' *Prometheus Bound*

Aeschylus' play *Prometheus Bound* begins with Strength (Kratos) and Force (Bia), brutish servants of an autocratic Zeus, having brought Prometheus to the remote and uninhabited land of Scythia. Hephaestus accompanies them. Kratos urges the reluctant Hephaestus to obey the commands of Father Zeus and bind Prometheus in bonds of steel and pin him with a stake through his chest to the desolate crags. It was Hephaestus' own brilliant "flower" of fire, deviser of all the arts, that Prometheus stole, and for this error ("sin" is not an inappropriate translation) he must pay to all the gods "so that he might learn to bear the sovereignty of Zeus and abandon his love and championship of mortals" (10–17).

Aeschylus, with great skill and economy, provides us with the essentials for the conflict and the mood of the play. The violent struggle pits a harsh, young, and angry Zeus against the defiant determination of a glorious and philanthropic Prometheus.¹³

Hephaestus, in contrast to savage Strength and Force, is sensitive and humane; he curses his craft, hates the job he has to do, and pities the sleepless torment of Prometheus. Hephaestus also expresses an important theme of the play in his realization that Zeus has only recently seized supreme rule of gods and mortals: "The mind of Zeus is inexorable; and everyone is harsh when he first comes to power." The contrast is presumably intended to foreshadow the later Zeus, who will learn benevolence through experience, wisdom, and maturity. Certainly Zeus, fresh from his triumphant defeat of his father and the Titans, might indeed be uneasy and afraid. He may suffer the same fate as Cronus or Uranus before him; and Prometheus, his adversary, knows the terrifying secret that might lead to Zeus' undoing: Zeus must avoid the sea-nymph Thetis in his amorous pursuits, for she is destined to bear a son mightier than his father. In his knowledge of this lies Prometheus' defiant power and the threat of Zeus' ultimate downfall.

The first utterance of Prometheus after Strength, Force, and Hephaestus have done their work is glorious, perfectly capturing the great and indomitable spirit of the rebel and the oppressed (88–92):

O divine air and sky and swift-winged breezes, springs of rivers and countless laughter of sea waves, earth, mother of everything, and all-seeing circle of the sun, I call on you. See what I, a god, suffer at the hands of the gods.

In the course of the play, Prometheus expresses his bitterness because, although he with his mother fought on the side of Zeus against the Titans, his only reward is torment. It is typical of the tyrant to forget and turn against his former allies. Prometheus lists the many gifts he has given to humankind for whom he suffers now (442–506):

PROMETHEUS: Listen to the troubles that there were among mortals and how I gave them sense and mind, which they did not have before. I shall tell you this, not out of any censure of humankind, but to explain the good intention of my gifts. In the beginning they had eyes to look, but looked in vain, and ears to hear, but did not hear, but like the shapes of dreams they wandered in confusion the whole of their long life. They did not know of brick-built houses that face the sun or carpentry, but dwelt beneath the ground like tiny ants in the depths of sunless caves. They did not have any secure way of distinguishing winter or



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blossoming spring or fruitful summer, but they did everything without judgment, until I showed them the rising and the setting of the stars, difficult to discern. (442–458) 10

And indeed I discovered for them numbers, a lofty kind of wisdom, and letters and their combination, an art that fosters memory of all things, the mother of the Muses' arts. I first harnessed animals, enslaving them to the yoke to give relief to mortals in their greatest toils, and I made horses docile under the reins of the chariot, the delight of the highest wealth and luxury. No one before me discovered the seamen's vessels which with wings of sail are beaten by the waves. Such are the contrivances I, poor wretch, have found for mortals, but I myself have no device by which I may escape my present pain. (459–471)

CHORUS: You suffer an ill-deserved torment, and confused in mind and heart are all astray; like some bad doctor who has fallen ill, you yourself cannot devise a remedy to effect a cure. (472–475) 20

PROMETHEUS: Listen to the rest, and you will be even more amazed at the kinds of skills and means that I devised; the greatest this: if anyone fell sick, there existed no defense, neither food nor drink nor salve, but through lack of medicines they wasted away until I showed them the mixing of soothing remedies by which they free themselves from all diseases. I set forth the many ways of the prophetic art. I was the first to determine which dreams would of necessity turn out to be true, and I established for them the difficult interpretation of sounds and omens of the road and distinguished the precise meaning of the flight of birds with crooked talons, which ones are by nature lucky and propitious, and what mode of life each had, their mutual likes, dislikes, and association; the smoothness of the innards and the color of the bile that would meet the pleasure of the gods, and the dappled beauty of the liver's lobe. I burned the limbs enwrapped in fat and the long shank and set mortals on the path to this difficult art of sacrifice, and made clear the fiery signs, obscure before. Such were these gifts of mine. And the benefits hidden deep within the earth, copper, iron, silver, and gold—who could claim that he had found them before me? No one, I know full well, unless he wished to babble on in vain. 30

In a brief utterance learn the whole story: all arts come to mortals from Prometheus. (476–506) 40

When Hermes, Zeus' messenger, appears in the last episode, Prometheus is arrogant and insulting in his refusal to bow to the threats of even more terrible suffering and reveal his secret. The play ends with the fulfillment of the promised torment; the earth shakes and cracks, thunder and lightning accompany wind and storm as Prometheus, still pinned to the rock, is plunged beneath the earth by the cataclysm; there he will be plagued by the eagle daily tearing his flesh and gnawing his liver. Prometheus' final utterance echoes and affirms the fiery heat and mighty spirit of his first invocation: "O majesty of earth, my mother, O air and sky whose circling brings light for all to share. You see me, how I suffer unjust torments."

Io, Zeus, and Prometheus

In order to appreciate Aeschylus' depiction of Zeus and his vision of the final outcome of the conflict between Zeus and Prometheus,¹⁴ we must introduce the story of Io, a pivotal figure in *Prometheus Bound*.¹⁵ In the series of exchanges



Mercury and Argus (1659), by Diego Velázquez (1599–1660); oil on canvas, 50 × 97 $\frac{5}{8}$ in. Velázquez fits the two figures, human and divine, and the cow into the rectangular and cavelike space, whose size was dictated by its original placement above a window. Mercury, stealthy and watchful, grasps his sword in his right hand, and his muscular upper torso and arms, with the disreputable felt hat, are quite different from usual and more heroic representations of the god. The light falls on Argus, portrayed as a weary guard, as he begins to fall asleep. The picture is a masterpiece of silence and foreboding. (Erich Lessing/*Art Resource*, NY)



Closer Look

between Prometheus and the various characters who come to witness his misery, the scene with Io is particularly significant in terms of eventual reconciliation and knowledge.

Io was loved by Zeus; she was a priestess of Hera and could not avoid detection by the goddess. Zeus failed to deceive Hera, who in retaliation turned Io into a white cow,¹⁶ and to guard her new possession, she set Argus over her. Argus, whose parentage is variously given, had many eyes (the number varies from four in Aeschylus to one hundred in Ovid) and was called Argus Panoptes (the “all-seeing”); because his eyes never slept all at once, he could have Io under constant surveillance. Zeus therefore sent Hermes to rescue Io; Hermes lulled Argus to sleep by telling him stories and then cut off his head—hence his title **Argeiphontes**, or “slayer of Argus.” Hera set Argus’ eyes in the tail of the peacock, the bird with which she is especially associated. Io still could not escape Hera’s jealousy; Hera sent a gadfly that so maddened her that she wandered miserably over the whole world until finally she came to Egypt. There by the Nile, Zeus restored her human form, and she gave birth to a son, Epaphus.¹⁷

In *Prometheus Bound*, Aeschylus describes Io’s sufferings in some detail to illustrate the ultimate wisdom, justice, and mercy of an all-powerful Zeus. In agony because of the stings of the gadfly and tormented by the ghost of Argus, Io flees over the earth in mad frenzy. She asks why Zeus has punished her, an innocent victim of Hera’s brutal resentment, and longs for the release of death. This is how the uncomprehending Io tells Prometheus of her anguish (645–682):

Again and again in the night, visions would appear to me in my room and entice me with seductive words: “O blessed maiden, why do you remain a virgin for so long when it is possible for you to achieve the greatest of marriages? For Zeus is inflamed by the shafts of desire and longs to make love to you. Do not, my child, reject the bed of Zeus but go out to the deep meadow of Lerna where the flocks and herds of your father graze, so that the longing of the eye of Zeus may be requited.” I, poor wretch, was troubled every night by such dreams until at last I dared to tell my father about them. He sent numerous messengers to

Delphi and Dodona to find out what he must do or say to appease the gods; and they returned with difficult and obscure answers, cryptically worded. At last an unambiguous injunction was delivered to Inachus, clearly ordering him to evict me from his house and city to wander without a home to the ends of the earth; if he did not comply, the fiery thunderbolt of Zeus would strike and annihilate his whole race. (645–668) 10

In obedience to this oracle of Apollo, my father, unwilling as was I, expelled and drove me from my home; indeed the bridle bit of Zeus forcefully compelled him to do such things. Straightway my body was changed and my mind distorted; with horns, as you can see, and pursued by the sharp stings of a gadfly, I rushed in convulsive leaps to the clear stream of Cerchnea and the spring of Lerna. The giant herdsman Argus, savage in his rage, accompanied me, watching with his countless eyes my every step. A sudden unexpected fate deprived him of his life; but I, driven mad by the stings of the gadfly, wander from land to land under the scourge of god. (669–682) 20

As the scene continues, Prometheus foretells the subsequent course of Io's wanderings. Eventually, she will find peace in Egypt, where (848–851):

Zeus will make you sane by the touch of his fearless hand—the touch alone; and you will bear a son, Epaphus, “Him of the Touch,” so named from his begetting at the hand of Zeus.

Aeschylus' version of the conception of **Epaphus** is religious. Io has been chosen by Zeus and has suffered at the hands of Hera for the fulfillment of a destiny, and she will conceive not through rape but by the gentle touch of the hand of god. Prometheus, with the oracular power of his mother, foresees the generations descended from Io, the culmination of his narrative being the birth of the great hero Heracles, who will help Zeus in the final release of Prometheus. Thus, the divine plan is revealed and the absolute power of almighty Zeus is achieved; in mature confidence he will rest secure, without fear of being overthrown, as the supreme and benevolent father of both gods and mortals.

As Aeschylus' other plays on Prometheus survive only as titles and fragments, we do not know how he conceived details in the ultimate resolution. From Hesiod (p. 91) we know that Heracles, through the agency of Zeus, was responsible for killing the eagle and releasing Prometheus—after Prometheus had revealed the fatal secret about mating with Thetis. Conflicting and obscure testimony has Chiron, the centaur, involved in some way, as Aeschylus seems to predict; Chiron, wounded by Heracles, gives up his life and his immortality in a bargain for the release of Prometheus.¹⁸

Zeus and Lycaon and the Wickedness of Mortals

Prometheus had a son, Deucalion, and Epimetheus had a daughter, Pyrrha. Their story, from Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, involves a great flood sent by Zeus (Jupiter) to punish mortals for their wickedness. In the passage given here, Jupiter tells an assembly of the gods how he, a god, became a man to test the truth of the rumors of human wickedness in the age of iron. There follows an account of Jupiter's anger at the evil of mortals, in particular Lycaon (1. 211–252).



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"Reports of the wickedness of the age had reached my ears; wishing to find them false, I slipped down from high Olympus and I, a god, roamed the earth in the form of a man. Long would be the delay to list the number of evils and where they were found; the iniquitous stories themselves fell short of the truth. I had crossed the mountain Maenalus, bristling with the haunts of animals, and Cyllene, and the forests of cold Lycaeus; from these ridges in Arcadia I entered the realm and inhospitable house of the tyrant Lycaon, as the dusk of evening was leading night on. (211–219)

"I gave signs that a god had come in their midst; the people began to pray but Lycaon first laughed at their piety and then cried: 'I shall test whether this man is a god or a mortal, clearly and decisively.' He planned to kill me unawares in the night while I was deep in sleep. This was the test of truth that suited him best. But he was not content even with this; with a knife he slit the throat of one of the hostages sent to him by the Molossians and, as the limbs were still warm with life, some he boiled until tender and others he roasted over a fire. As soon as he placed them on the table, I with a flame of vengeance brought the home down upon its gods, worthy of such a household and such a master. (220–231)

"Lycaon himself fled in terror, and when he reached the silence of the country he howled as in vain he tried to speak. His mouth acquired a mad ferocity arising from his basic nature, and he turned his accustomed lust for slaughter against the flocks and now took joy in their blood. His clothes were changed to hair; his arms to legs; he became a wolf retaining vestiges of his old form. The silver of the hair and the violent countenance were the same; the eyes glowed in the same way; the image of ferocity was the same.¹⁹ (232–239)

"One house had fallen but not one house only deserved to perish. Far and wide on the earth the Fury holds power; you would think that an oath had been sworn in the name of crime. Let all quickly suffer the penalties they deserve. Thus my verdict stands." (240–244)

Some cried approval of the words of Jove and added goads to his rage, others signified their assent by applause. But the loss of the human race was grievous to them all and they asked what the nature of the world would be like bereft of mortals, who would bring incense to the altars, and if Jupiter was prepared to give the world over to the ravagings of animals. As they asked these questions the king of the gods ordered them not to be alarmed, for all that would follow would be his deep concern; and he promised a race of wondrous origin unlike the one that had preceded. (245–252)

The Flood

Set upon destroying humankind, Jupiter rejects the idea of hurling his thunderbolts against the world because he fears they may start a great conflagration that could overwhelm the universe. As Ovid continues the story, the god has decided on a different means of punishment: a great flood (260–290). The motif of the Flood is one of the most important and universal in myth and legend.²⁰



Audio

A different punishment pleased him more: to send down from every region of the sky torrents of rain and destroy the human race under the watery waves. Straightway he imprisoned the North Wind, and such other blasts as put storm clouds to flight in the caves of Aeolus, and let loose the South Wind who flew

with drenched wings, his dread countenance cloaked in darkness black as pitch; his beard was heavy with rain, water flowed from his hoary hair, clouds nestled on his brow, and his wings and garments dripped with moisture. And as he pressed the hanging clouds with his broad hand, he made a crash, and out of them thick rains poured down from the upper air. The messenger of Juno, Iris, adorned in varied hues, drew up the waters and brought nourishment to the clouds. The crops were leveled and the farmers' hopeful prayers lay ruined and bemoaned the labor of the long year in vain destroyed. (269–273) 10

Nor was the wrath of Jove content with his realm, the sky. His brother Neptune of the sea gave aid with waves as reinforcements. He called together the rivers and, when they had entered the dwelling of their master, said: "Now I cannot resort to a long exhortation. Pour forth your strength, this is the need—open wide your domains, and all barriers removed, give full rein to your streams." This was his command. They went back home and opened wide their mouths for their waters to roll in their unbridled course over the plains. Neptune himself struck the earth with his trident; it trembled and with the quake laid open paths for the waters. The streams spread from their course and rushed over the open fields and swept away, together and at once, the trees and crops, cattle, human beings, houses, and their inner shrines with sacred statues. If any house remained and was able to withstand being thrown down by so great an evil, yet a wave still higher touched its highest gables, and towers overcome lay submerged in the torrent. (274–290) 20

Deucalion and Pyrrha

Ovid provides further elaborate and poetical description of the ravages of the terrible flood and then concentrates upon the salvation of the pious couple, Deucalion (the Greek Noah) and his wife, Pyrrha, and the repopulation of the world (311–421).

The greatest part of life was swept away by water; those whom the water spared were overcome by slow starvation because of lack of food. (311–312)

The territory of Phocis separates the terrain of Thessaly from that of Boeotia, a fertile area when it was land, but in this crisis it had suddenly become part of the sea and a wide field of water. Here a lofty mountain, Parnassus by name, reaches with its two peaks up to the stars, the heights extending beyond the clouds. When Deucalion with his wife was carried in his little boat to this mountain and ran aground (for the deep waters had covered the rest of the land) they offered worship to the Corycian nymphs,²¹ the deities of the mountain, and prophetic Themis, who at that time held oracular power there. No man was better than Deucalion nor more devoted to justice, and no woman more reverent towards the gods than his wife, Pyrrha. (313–323) 10

When Jupiter saw the earth covered with a sea of water and only one man and one woman surviving out of so many thousands of men and women, both innocent and both devout worshipers of deity, he dispelled the clouds, and after the North Wind had cleared the storm, revealed the earth to the sky and the upper air to the world below. The wrath of the sea did not endure and the ruler of the deep laid aside his trident and calmed the waves. He summoned the sea-god Triton, who rose above the waters, his shoulders encrusted with shellfish; he



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ordered him to blow into his resounding conch shell and by this signal to recall 20
the waves and the rivers. Triton took up the hollow horn which grows from the
lowest point of the spiral, coiling in ever widening circles. Whenever he blows
into his horn in the middle of the deep, its sounds fill every shore to east and
west. Now too, as the god put the horn to his lips moist with his dripping beard
and gave it breath, it sounded the orders of retreat and was heard by all the
waves on land and on the sea, and as they listened all were checked. (324–342)

Once more the sea had shores and streams were held within their channels,
rivers subsided, and hills were seen to rise up. Earth emerged and the land grew
in extent as the waves receded. And after a length of time the tops of the woods
were uncovered and showed forth, a residue of mud left clinging to the leaves. 30
The world had been restored. (343–348)

When Deucalion saw the earth devoid of life and the profound silence of its
desolation, tears welled up in his eyes as he spoke to Pyrrha thus: “O my cousin,
and my wife, the only woman left, related to me by family ties of blood, then
joined to me in marriage, now danger itself unites us. We two alone are the host
of the whole world from east to west; the sea holds all the rest. Besides assurance
of our life is not yet completely certain. Even now the clouds above strike terror in
my heart. What feelings would you have now, poor dear, if you had been snatched
to safety by the Fates without me? In what way could you have been able to bear 40
your fear alone? Who would have consoled you as you grieved? For I, believe me,
would have followed, if the sea had taken you, dear wife, and the sea would have
taken me with you. How I wish I might be able to repopulate the earth by the arts
of my father and infuse the molded clods of earth with life. As it is, the race of
mortals rests in just us two—thus have the gods ordained—and we remain the
only vestiges of human beings.” Thus he spoke and they wept. (348–367)

They decided to pray to the goddess Themis and seek help through her holy
oracles with no delay. Together they approached the waves of the river Ceph-
isus, which, although not yet clear, was cutting its accustomed course. When
they had drawn water and sprinkled their heads and clothes, they turned their
steps from there to the temple of the goddess; its pediments were discolored 50
with vile moss and its altars stood without fire. As they reached the steps of the
temple, both fell forward on the ground, and in dread awe implanted kisses on
the cold stone. They spoke as follows: “If the divine majesty is won over and
made soft by just prayers, if the anger of the gods is turned aside, tell, O Themis,
by what art the loss of the human race may be repaired and give help, O most
gentle deity, in our drowned world.” (367–380)

The goddess was moved and gave her oracle: “Go away from my temple,
cover your heads and unloose the fastenings of your garments, and toss the
bones of the great mother behind your back.” For a long time they were stupe-
fied at this; Pyrrha first broke the silence by uttering her refusal to obey the 60
orders of the goddess; with fearful prayer she begged indulgence, for she feared
to hurt the shade of her mother by tossing her bones. But all the while they
sought another explanation and mulled over, alone and together, the dark and
hidden meaning of the obscure words given by the oracle. Then the son of Pro-
metheus soothed the daughter of Epimetheus with pleasing words: “Unless my
ingenuity is wrong, oracles are holy and never urge any evil; the great parent is
the earth; I believe that the stones in the body of earth are called her bones. We
are ordered to throw these behind our backs.” (381–394)

Although the Titan's daughter was moved by the interpretation of her husband, her hope was still in doubt; to this extent they both distrusted heaven's admonitions. But what harm would there be in trying? They left the temple, covered their heads, unloosed their garments, and tossed the stones behind their steps as they were ordered. The stones (who would believe this if the antiquity of tradition did not bear testimony?) began to lose their hardness and rigidity and gradually grew soft and in their softness assumed a shape. Soon as they grew and took on a more pliant nature, the form of a human being could be seen, in outline not distinct, most like crude statues carved in marble, just begun and not sufficiently completed. The part of the stones that was of earth dampened by some moisture was converted into flesh; what was solid and unable to be so transformed was changed into bone; what once had been a vein in the stone remained with the same name; in a short time, through the will of the gods, the stones hurled by the hands of the man assumed the appearance of men, and those cast by the woman were converted into women. Hence we are a hard race and used to toils and offer proof of the origin from which we were sprung. (395–415)

The earth of her own accord produced other animals of different sorts, after the moisture that remained was heated by the fire of the sun; and the mud and soggy marshes began to swell because of the heat, and fertile seeds of things began to grow nourished by the life-giving earth, as in a mother's womb, and gradually took on a certain form. (416–421)

Deucalion and Pyrrha had a son Hellen, the eponymous ancestor of the Greek people; for the Greeks called themselves Hellenes and their country Hellas.²²

Succession Myths and Other Motifs

Literature of the ancient Near East has many parallels to Hesiod's account of genesis and the gods. One of the most striking is the archetypal motif known as the Succession Myth. In the Babylonian epic of creation, which begins with the words by which it is entitled (*Enuma Elish*, "When on high"), Marduk plays a role similar to that of Zeus in the conflict for power; and Marduk, like Zeus, attains ultimate control by defeating a monster, Tiamat, who thus resembles Typhoeus. Likewise the epic *Kingship in Heaven* reveals common thematic patterns; especially startling is the episode that tells how Kumarbi defeats Anu by biting off his genitals, a brutal act not unlike the castration of Uranus by Cronus. The flood archetype is particularly fascinating because of its presence worldwide, in virtually all cultures (see note 20). The wickedness of mortals and their punishment, as well as their salvation, are also persistent themes. The Appendix at the end of this chapter provides a more detailed identification of parallels between the myths of Greece and those of the ancient Near East.

Among the many themes inherent in the character and career of Zeus himself, the following deserve special emphasis. Even though Zeus was a god, his life illustrates special motifs that appear again and again not only in the lives of other deities but also in the mortal lives of the heroes of saga, to be sure with infinite variations and amplifications. Zeus is the child of extraordinary parents; both of them are gods. The circumstances of his birth are unusual or difficult; he must avoid being swallowed by his father. He must be brought up in secret, and his life as an infant is both precarious and charmed, progressing in accordance

with the motif of the Divine Child. He grows up close to nature and the world of animals; and, after an idyllic childhood, with special care and training, upon reaching manhood, he must come into his own by overcoming challenges and adversaries: his father Cronus and the Titans, the Giants, and Prometheus. Very special on the list of his triumphs is the slaying of a dragon. By killing Typhoeus, Zeus, the supreme god, may be proclaimed as the archetypal dragonslayer—one of the most powerful and symbolic of all divine and heroic achievements.

In the end, as we shall see in the next chapter, Zeus emerges as the ultimate victor and wins a bride, a kingdom, and supreme power. He triumphs to become almighty god, although even then his exploits and trials are by no means over.

Appendix to Chapter 4

Parallels in Myths of Greece and the Ancient Near East

Five basic myths are important for the identification of parallels in the myths of ancient Near Eastern civilizations. These are the myths of Creation, Succession, the Flood, the Descent to the Underworld, and the hero-king Gilgamesh. They have striking parallels in Greek mythology, as we have already observed. “Are there migrating myths?” asks Walter Burkert, and he and others answer that the similarities are undeniable evidence for the influence of Near Eastern cultures on Greek mythology. How this influence traveled cannot be known precisely, but trade is the most likely means, as it has been shown that contacts between the Greek and Near Eastern worlds flourished especially in two periods, the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries and the eighth and seventh centuries B.C.²³ Near Eastern myths appear in the cultures of Sumer and Akkad—southern and northern Mesopotamia, respectively. The Sumerians were the earliest (from the fourth millennium B.C.) to develop a civilization with urban centers, such as Ur and Uruk. They developed *cuneiform* (“wedge-shaped”) script on clay tablets, and their religious architecture was distinguished by *ziggurats* (temple towers). They were absorbed by Semitic peoples speaking a different language (Akkadian) but still using cuneiform script. The chief Akkadian urban center (from the late third millennium) was Babylon, which reached its first zenith under King Hammurabi, around 1800 B.C. Babylon was conquered in about 1250 B.C. by the northern Akkadians, who established the Assyrian empire, with its center at Nineveh.

Among the peoples associated with the Akkadians were the Hurrians of northern Syria, who in their turn were absorbed by the Hittites after about 1400 B.C. The Hittite empire flourished in Anatolia (the central and eastern area of modern Turkey) during the second millennium B.C., with its center at Hattusas, the modern Boghaz-Köy. Hittite myths absorbed Hurrian themes and the names of Hurrian gods, and several of these myths have themes in common with Greek myth. The same is true of Egyptian, Phoenician, and Hebraic myths, the last-named being more familiar to Western readers, especially in the biblical Christian narratives of Genesis (Chapters 1 and 2), Psalms (many references, for example, Psalms 33 and 104), and Job (Chapter 38).

Like Hesiod, the Sumerian, Babylonian, and Akkadian poets do not narrate a myth of creation by an intelligent creator. Their concern, like Hesiod's, is with the bringing of order out of disorder, or, rather, out of a concept similar to the Greek *Chaos* (“Void”). Thus, their myths of creation also involve myths

of succession and, to some extent, myths of the Flood and the survival and re-creation of humankind. The best-known myth of creation is in the Babylonian *Epic of Creation*, usually identified by its opening words, *Enuma Elish* (“When on high . . .”), which was probably composed in the early years of the second millennium B.C. In this version, the gods come into existence from the union of Apsu and Tiamat—the fresh water and saltwater oceans, respectively. From them descend Anu (the sky) and Ea or Enki (the earth-god), who is also the god of wisdom. From Ea, Marduk is born, after Ea has destroyed Apsu. Tiamat then prepares to attack the younger gods, who entrust their defense to Marduk and make him their king, after their leader, Enlil, has proved unequal to the challenge. Armed with bow and arrow, thunderbolt, and storm-winds, Marduk attacks Tiamat, fills her with the winds, and splits her body. The following is part of the battle, which should be compared with Hesiod’s account of the battle between Zeus and Typhoeus (see pp. 84–86):

Face to face they came, Tiamat and Marduk. . . .
 They engaged in combat, they closed for battle.
 The Lord spread his net and made it encircle her,
 To her face he dispatched the *imhullu*-wind. . . .
 Tiamat opened her mouth to swallow it,
 And he forced in the *imhullu*-wind so that she could not
 Close her lips.
 Fierce winds distend her belly. . . .
 He shot an arrow which pierced her belly,
 Split her down the middle and slit her heart,
 Vanquished her and extinguished her life.²⁴

After his victory, Marduk places half of Tiamat’s body above the earth and there, in the sky, he creates Esharra, the home of the gods, while Tiamat’s followers, led by Kingu, are bound. Marduk then organizes the gods and the world and, on the advice of Ea, orders the creation of humankind from the blood of Kingu, who is killed. The work of humankind is to serve the gods, and Marduk’s temple of Esagila, with its ziggurat, is built in Babylon. The poem ends with the enumeration of the fifty names of Marduk.

About two hundred years later than *Enuma Elish* (ca. 1700 B.C.), the Babylonian epic of *Atrahasis* was written down. Atrahasis is the supremely wise man—his name means “extra-wise,” corresponding to Ut-napishtim of the *Gilgamesh Epic*, the Sumerian hero Ziusudra, the Hebrew Noah, and the Greek Prometheus and Deucalion (the former being the pre-Olympian god of wisdom and craftsmanship and the latter the survivor of the Flood). In the myth of Atrahasis, the gods complain of the hard labor that they must perform for Enlil and threaten to rebel against him. Enlil orders the creation of humankind to perform the toil of canal-digging and other labors for the gods. Enlil orders the death of the intelligent god Geshtu-e, from whose flesh and blood, mixed with clay, humankind is created, seven males and seven females. After a long period of time Atrahasis, advised by Enki, survives the flood sent by Enlil, who has determined to destroy humankind because their noise disturbs the peace of the gods. Enlil is furious when he sees the boat in which Atrahasis has survived, but the poem ends with a reconciliation between Enlil and Enki, by which the human race is allowed to continue.



Greece and the Near East.

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The best-known version of the myth of the Flood is narrated in the *Epic of Gilgamesh* by the heroic survivor, Ut-napishtim, whom Gilgamesh visits after a journey through the hitherto impassable “mountains of Mashu” and across the waters of death. Here, too, Enlil is furious at the survival of Ut-napishtim, but again there is a reconciliation. Ut-napishtim lives, immortal, far off “at the mouth of the rivers”; humankind, re-created, cannot escape the evils that occur to the living, nor can they escape death. Gilgamesh ultimately fails in his quest for immortality, and the final tablet (no. xii) of the poem describes the retention of his dead friend, Enkidu, in the world of the dead.²⁵ Gilgamesh himself was originally a historical figure, ruler of the Sumerian city of Uruk (modern Warka, in central Iraq) ca. 2700 B.C. His legends were incorporated into the Assyrian version of his epic, dating from about 1700 B.C., written on eleven clay tablets, to which a twelfth was added much later. Different versions exist of the epic, the composition of which evolved over a lengthy period. Later tradition claimed that a scholar-priest Sinleqqiunninni was the author.²⁶

Gilgamesh, the wise hero and slayer of monstrous beings, has obvious similarities with Greek Odysseus and Heracles (who is also identified with Ninurta, son of Enlil, and with the underworld god, Nergal, consort of Ereshkigal). Like the Babylonian Atrahasis and the Greek Odysseus, he is supremely intelligent. Here are the opening lines of the first tablet of the poem:

[Of him who] found out all things, I [shall te]ll the land,
 [Of him who] experienced everything, I [shall te]ach the whole.
 He searched [?] lands [?] everywhere.
 He who experienced the whole gained complete wisdom.
 He found out what was secret and uncovered what was hidden.
 He brought back a tale of times before the Flood.
 He had journeyed far and wide, weary and at last resigned.
 He engraved all toils on a memorial monument of stone.²⁷

A brief summary of the poem runs as follows. The strong and handsome Gilgamesh is two-thirds divine and one-third human. As king of Uruk, he acts oppressively toward his people, and therefore the gods create a rival for him, valiant Enkidu, a primeval hunter in the forest, quite the opposite of the civilized Gilgamesh. After sexual intercourse with a harlot, Enkidu is depleted of his wild character and eventually challenges Gilgamesh in a wrestling match. Although Gilgamesh defeats Enkidu, they become devoted comrades and their loving friendship now becomes a major theme. They set out together on a quest to cut down the sacred trees in the Pine (or Cedar) Forest in the mountains of southwest Iran, after having killed its guardian Humbaba (or Huwawa), the Terrible. These labors accomplished, upon their return to Uruk, Gilgamesh is confronted by the goddess Ishtar, who desires to marry him. When he rejects her, she sends down the terrifying and destructive Bull of Heaven, which the two heroes kill. Because they have defiled the sacred Forest and killed the Bull of Heaven, the gods decide that one of them, Enkidu, must die. All the long while that Enkidu suffers painfully, Gilgamesh is by his side, and when Enkidu dies, he is overcome with grief. Gilgamesh, horrified by the reality of death and decay, decides to find the secret of immortality. His encounter with Ut-napishtim, the survivor of the Flood, has already been described.

In addition to those mentioned here, many parallels between the Sumerian and Greek heroes and their legends can be found, for example, in the contact of Odysseus with the Underworld and the land of Alcinöus and the Phaeacians (similar to the realm of Ut-napishtim “at the mouth of the rivers”). Similarities between the story of the *Iliad* and that of the *Epic of Gilgamesh* are also readily apparent, prominent among them being the comradeship of Achilles and Patroclus and that of Gilgamesh and Enkidu.

On the other hand, the myth of the Flood is not prominent in classical Greek myth. It appears more fully (in Latin) in Ovid’s narratives of the great flood (*Metamorphoses* 1. 260–421: see pp. 99–103) and of the Lydian flood in the story of Baucis and Philemon (*Metamorphoses* 8. 689–720: see p. 663).

Myths of succession and the separation of sky and earth appear also in Hittite narratives, of which the best known is the poem called *Kingship in Heaven*, in which Kumarbi (who corresponds to the Sumerian Enlil) bites off the genitals of the sky-god, Anu, and swallows them. Inside Kumarbi the storm-god (Teshub or Tarkhun) develops from the genitals of Anu, and after his birth he plots with Anu to overthrow Kumarbi. The extant poem breaks off as Teshub prepares for battle, but it appears that he defeated Kumarbi. Thus Anu, Kumarbi/Enlil, and Teshub/Marduk are parallel to Uranus, Cronus, and Zeus in Greek myth. In the Hittite *Song of Ullikummis*, Ea cuts off the feet of Ullikummis, a giant made of diorite (a kind of very hard stone), 9,000 leagues in height, created by Kumarbi as a threat to the gods. After his mutilation, the gods, led by Teshub, battle with Ullikummis (the tablet breaks off at this point, but no doubt the gods prevailed).²⁸

The theme of descent to the Underworld is also prominent in Near Eastern myth and has many parallels in Greek myth. The most important myth on this theme is narrated in the short Akkadian poem, *The Descent of Ishtar to the Underworld*, dating from the end of the second millennium B.C. It was preceded by a Sumerian version, about three times as long, in which Ishtar is called by her Sumerian name, Inanna.²⁹ Inanna/Ishtar is daughter of Anu (and therefore one of the earlier generation of gods) and sister of Ereshkigal, queen of the Underworld and wife of Nergal. Ishtar is a goddess of war but also the goddess of love and sexual creation, and thus has much in common with Aphrodite. While Ereshkigal corresponds to the Greek Persephone, Ishtar is like Persephone in that she returns from the Underworld, and like Eurydice (wife of Orpheus) in that she must return to the Underworld if certain conditions are not fulfilled on her journey back to the upper world. Her consort, Dumuzi (Tammuz), is similar to Adonis and Attis in Greek myth.

In both narratives Ishtar decides to visit the Underworld; knowing that she may be killed there, she leaves instructions with her vizier that will ensure her resurrection if she does not return within a certain time. She is stripped of her ornaments and clothing as she goes through the seven gates of the Underworld, and Ereshkigal orders her death. In the Sumerian version her corpse is hung from a peg. She is brought back to life through the advice of Enki (Sumerian version) or the agency of her vizier (Akkadian version). In the Akkadian version, she receives back her clothing and ornaments, and the poem ends with mourning for the death of her consort, Dumuzi (Tammuz). In the Sumerian version, Ishtar is angry with Dumuzi for his refusal to dress in mourning for her absence, and in anger she hands him over to the demons who were to take her back to the Underworld if she failed to fulfill Ereshkigal’s conditions. Only in 1963 was the

Sumerian tablet published that describes the annual death and resurrection of Dumuzi, and with his return the renewal of crops on the earth.³⁰

It must be stressed that many parallels between Near Eastern and Greek myths may be no more than that chance appearance of themes common to many mythologies, with no direct influence. Yet, in the instances of the succession myth, the Flood, the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, and the myth of Ishtar and Dumuzi, it is most probable that there was some direct contact between Near Eastern and Greek storytellers, in which case we have strong evidence for Eastern sources in early Greek mythography. The Greeks owed many debts to the civilizations with whom they came into contact, not only in the Near East but also in Egypt. They used and transformed what they heard, saw, and read into works of art cast in their own image.³¹

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